

TRIBUNE-REVIEW

Rep. Murtha proposes network of trails

By Jerry Storey
TRIBUNE-REVIEW
Sunday, September 22, 2002

If U.S. Rep. John Murtha is successful, a network of southwestern Pennsylvania trails may one day be part of the elite National Trails System.

The Johnstown Democrat recently introduced legislation, called "The Paths to the Ohio Trail Study Act," aimed at eventually winning a designation as either a National Historic Trail, or a National Scenic Trail, through the program administered by the National Park Service.

Although the regional trails would be eligible for some additional federal funds, the designation "is not a means to pry more money" from the government, Linda M. McKenna Boxx, president of the Allegheny Trail Alliance, emphasized.

The Allegheny Trail Alliance is made up of organizations developing the Great Allegheny Passage from Pittsburgh to Cumberland Md., including the Youghiogheny River Trail. The Great Allegheny Passage, and the Mainline Canal Greenway, nicknamed the "double burger" because it is to run from Pittsburgh and Harrisburg, would be included in the national designation. So would a number of smaller interconnecting paths, such as the Five Star Trail in Westmoreland County.

This trail network would be among only 22 paths nationwide to earn the special recognition. It will put the regional trails on the map, Boxx and others noted.

The venerable Appalachian Trail was the first designated a National Scenic Trail under the 1968 legislation that established the program. One of the more unusual National Historic Trails is the Iditarod in Alaska, a section of which, crossing a frozen Norton Bay, melts away in the summer.

The designation is more than just an honor. Although the Park Service doesn't manage the National Trails System, it provides technical assistance for it, with NPS staff assigned to individual National Trails.

But Murtha's bill is only the first step in what will likely be a long journey.

The legislation that created the National Trails System requires a four-step process for new designations, including an initial approval by Congress for the study, and a second vote later for the designation. The process typically takes an average of 10 years, according to Steve Elkinton, National Park Service program leader for the National Trails System.

Even on an accelerated schedule, the time frames in the legislation for the study and other steps would take about seven years, he estimated.

The study would determine if the trail network is eligible for the designation, and

the category into which it fits. At first consideration, such southwestern Pennsylvania paths as the Youghiogheny River Trail would appear to be recreational, for biking and hiking, and might fit best under the National Scenic Trail category.

However, Murtha's legislation emphasizes the historic ties the region's trails have to the French and Indian War and the Ohio River Basin. Brad Clemenson, a Murtha spokesman, pointed out that the trails are "paths to the Ohio."

Elkinton said the success of a National Trail effort is largely a function of local trail organizations and the amount of public interest generated.

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